PULLED BISON AREPAS
WITH ELDERBERRY BBQ SAUCE

serves 8

The Columbia Plateau falls to the west of Yellowstone and the Rocky Mountain region where bison have roamed since prehistoric times. While they were not common in the region, the meat was sometimes acquired through trade.

Mariah Gladstone (Blackfeet, Cherokee) grew up in Northwest Montana and is the founder of Indigikitchen (Indigikitchen.com), a platform where she teaches people about Indigenous foods both online and off. This sweet-tangy elderberry barbecue sauce is one of her most popular recipes. Here, she makes pulled bison sandwiches with arepas, corn-based flatbreads that use a precooked (but not nixtamalized) corn flour. She likes to braise her meat in a slow cooker for ease. If you'd like the sandwiches to come together faster, you can also use an electric pressure cooker (see Note).

Prepare the bison: In a small bowl, stir together the maple sugar (to taste), paprika, garlic powder, onion powder, and salt.

Place the meat a slow cooker. Season with half of the spice mixture, rubbing it into the roast, then flip it over and use the remaining spice mixture to rub into the second side and the ends. Pour ⅔ cup water around the roast, not over it. Top with the tallow pieces. Cover and cook on low for 10 to 12 hours, or until the roast is fork-tender.

Meanwhile, make the barbecue sauce: In a medium saucepan, combine the dried berries and 2 cups water and cook over low heat for 30 minutes, stirring a few times, until the berries are soft and plump and have released much of their flavor into the liquid.

Transfer to a blender and let cool to warm. Puree the berries, then strain through two layers of cheesecloth back into the saucepan, discarding the solids.

Stir in the tomato sauce, vinegar, maple syrup, chili powder, onion powder, paprika, salt, and masa harina. Reduce the heat to low and simmer for 10 minutes, or until the sauce is thickened and there's a nice balance between the sweetness and tanginess from the vinegar. Add more masa harina, 1 teaspoon at a time, for a thicker sauce. Taste and season with more salt as needed.

When the roast is done, transfer to a large cutting board and use two forks to pull apart the meat. Drain and discard the liquid from the slow cooker and return the pulled meat to the slow cooker. Add 1½ cups of the barbecue sauce to the pulled meat. Cover and cook on high for 30 minutes to allow the flavors to meld. (Refrigerate any remaining sauce in an airtight container for up to 2 weeks.)

(recipe and ingredients continue)

BISON

- 2 to 3 tablespoons Maple Sugar (page 36) or store-bought
- 2½ teaspoons paprika
- 2 teaspoons garlic powder
- 2 teaspoons onion powder
- 1½ teaspoons fine sea salt
- 1 (4-pound) boneless bison roast, such as a chuck roast
- 3 tablespoons tallow, cut into tablespoons, or sunflower oil

BARBECUE SAUCE

- 1 cup dried elderberries
- 1 (15-ounce) can tomato sauce
- ¾ cup maple vinegar or cider vinegar
- ½ cup maple syrup
- 2 teaspoons chili powder
- 1½ teaspoons onion powder
- 1 teaspoon sweet paprika
- ½ teaspoon fine sea salt, plus more as needed
- 2 tablespoons masa harina, or more as needed